

Classroom in Crisis

There are more vacant posts than there are teachers in Uttar Pradesh, as the state's education system heads for a breakdown

At a time when the Centre has been boasting of the successful implementation of its Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan, here is a state where the fate of 3.25 crore students languishes in the dark. With an acute shortage of qualified and experienced teachers, both in primary as well as higher education institutes, the education system in Uttar Pradesh finds itself severely crippled. Most alarming is the condition of the primary schools, where out of the total

cal institutions. At present, in the nearly 289 private colleges of the state, 3,000 of the 15,000 sanctioned posts, from the level of professor to reader, are lying vacant. Even in the seven government colleges, 28 per cent posts are waiting to be filled. The problem has escalated to such a level that one faculty member is taking classes in three institutes at a period of time. "All this is happening in the knowledge of the members of the AICTE, the Uttar Pradesh

administration," says R.P. Singh, principal secretary of the primary education department.

In other sectors too, lack of qualified teachers is paralysing the education and research departments. For instance, the flying training institutes have fallen short of instructors. The young pilots are not ready to teach because there is an increased demand for pilots in the national and international airlines that offer better pay cheques. "In the next five years, the demand for young pilots will rise to 5,000 a year, while the output will remain at a paltry 1,000," says a senior officer in the Civil Aviation Ministry, who added that the Flying Training Institute in Kanpur is lying defunct. Shortage of instructors is one of the principal reasons behind

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ZERO SUM GAME

PRIMARY SCHOOLS There are 1.40 lakh primary schools in the state, where of the total 2.82 lakh sanctioned posts, 1.8 lakh are lying vacant.

GOVERNMENT COLLEGES Of the total 460 posts in seven government colleges, 130 posts have no takers.

PRIVATE COLLEGES In the 289 private colleges in the state, 3,000 of the total 15,000 posts are lying vacant. Moreover, a substantial portion of the 12,000 posts have been filled by fresh graduates, who have neither experience nor adequate qualifications.

2.82 lakh sanctioned posts, 1.8 lakh posts have no takers. So is the condition of the universities and colleges providing professional degrees in the areas of aviation, medical, engineering and agriculture, where about 50 per cent of the teaching work is either done by part-timers or ad hoc teachers.

"The problem in the technical institutes is so serious that a B.Tech graduate is teaching B.Tech students, without any prior teaching experience and proper qualification," says Vinay Pathak, member of the advisory committee on technical education of the All-India Council for Technical Education (AICTE), the supervisory and regulatory authority for all techni-

BITTER LESSONS: Students chat around in an empty classroom of the Lucknow University

Government and the Central Government, but no one is objecting to it," says a member of the AICTE.

According to Alok Ranjan, principal secretary, technical education, Uttar Pradesh, the root of the problem lies in getting qualified and experienced teachers for such institutes. Even the Institute for Research and Training for Teachers in Kanpur, an organisation formed to train teachers, is lying defunct. "The unfortunate part is that teachers do not want to teach as there is little money involved. They would rather be part of the district education

the institute's near closure. The agriculture universities in the state have also been bitten by this bug. "Our funds have been frozen since 1998 and because of this, we have not been able to overcome the shortfall. This is affecting the teaching and research programmes of the institute," says V.K. Suri, vice-chancellor of the Chandra Shekhar Azad Agriculture University in Kanpur. Singh says that there would be a requirement of more teachers in the near future because nearly 6,000 new primary schools are coming up in Uttar Pradesh every year. Will they be able to teach the somnolent administration a lesson?

by Subhash Mishra